GEHLOT'S GIG

The Congress government has brought in a handful of landmark rights-based welfare legislations

RAJASTHAN MINIMUM GUARANTEED INCOME ACT

Target: **The entire adult population**

- Makes employment of a minimum 125 days in a year, at Rs 255 a day, an entitlement for all
- In the absence of work, every adult in a BPL family to get Rs 1,000 a month
- It also guarantees a minimum monthly pension of Rs 1,000 to those above 55, the specially abled, widows, single women, to go up by 15 per cent annually
- It thus extends MNREGA by accounting for rural and urban job guarantees, while also bundling the minimum pension under one umbrella legislation

RAJASTHAN PLATFORM-BASED GIG WORKERS (REGISTRATION AND WELFARE) ACT

Target: **Estimated 300,000**

- Extends basic rights to gig workers, the first law in India to do so
- All gig workers will get registered with a unique ID
- A social security and welfare fund will be set up for them with a corpus of Rs 200 crore, including by levying a fee on aggregator platforms that employ them, who will also be liable to penalties for violations
- A welfare board will be set up, with representatives from gig workers as well as aggregators, besides bureaucrats

Platform-Based Gig Workers (Registration and Welfare) Bill, and the Minimum Income Guarantee Act.

As a politician, Gehlot has blithely courted the reputation—infamy, if you like—of one who pursues welfarism at any cost. For fiscal purists, his gift-wrapped bonanzas often breach the blurred border between genuinely ameliorative policies and outright freebies (see *Gehlot's Gift Economy*, June 23). The latter impulse has not ebbed one bit. On August 2, before the assembly was adjourned sine die, Gehlot's Congress government pushed through the Rajasthan State Farmers Debt Relief Commission Bill, 2023. One among the five bills passed on the final day of the session, it elicited much uproar. The Opposition called it a last-ditch "desperate attempt" by Gehlot to stay in the good graces of the voters before the year-end assembly election. But if the CM's votaries, in turn, called the 'Gehlot model of welfare governance' his USP, they would have been better served by citing the two bills mentioned above.

The Gig Workers Bill, for instance, is India's first legislative response to the increasing informalisation of the workforce.



"I HAVE BROUGHT IN NEW SCHEMES AND LAWS FROM THE VERY FIRST DAY OF THIS TERM"

ASHOK GEHLOT

Chief Minister, Rajasthan

Recent years have seen urban India reap the benefits of an explosion in online delivery platforms, but it has never addressed the corresponding boom in the floating population of delivery personnel—a phenomenon that has to be seen against the curse of joblessness. The temporary income security of being a delivery boy (or girl) is what an estimated 120 million of India's youth have to settle for. Despite some sporadic attention to the precarity of their working conditions, they have remained orphans of the new economy, beyond the pale of any state support. And at 26.4 per cent, Rajasthan ranks second after Haryana in the ignominious hierarchy of states with the highest unemployment in India—over thrice the national figure. Its gig workers number approximately 300,000. Though only the process of registration that will start now can reveal the actual figure, it's not a bloc that can swing any election.

The Rajasthan Minimum Guaranteed Income Act (RMGIA), similarly, births an idea whose time was widely seen to have come. Modelled on MNREGA (Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act), it goes beyond that UPA-era legislation by extending the concept of assured mandays of work to *all* families—which, for the first time, brings the urban poor within its arc. This demographic has attracted increasing attention in recent years. The first-ever official reckoning of its scale—'India: Urban Poverty Report, 2009'—had pegged the number of poor in the cities at 25 per cent. Even by the changed methodology using multidimensional poverty, the latest NITI Aayog estimate trims that down only to just below 9 per cent. A mammoth number, given that well over 500 million Indians live in cities now. No wonder even the Narendra Modi government was said to be seriously considering an 'Urban MNREGA' in its recent budgets, opting out owing to post-Covid fiscal pressures. Now, Gehlot earns the credit for being the first to roll out such a scheme, adding it to his list of rights-based welfare legislations. Like his Right to Health Act, brought in early this year, RMGIA makes it obligatory on the government to provide 125 days of work at a minimum of Rs 255 per day. And in the absence of any work, every adult in a BPL family gets Rs 1,000 a month. Already, 1.8 million single women with low incomes get a monthly stipend of Rs 1,000 (those above the age of 75 get Rs 1,500), and so do senior citizens above 55 years of age.

"These measures are proven welfare acts rather than freebies. RMGIA is an advancement on MNREGA. Once scorned by the BJP as wasteful expenditure, it became a resource to fall back on when there